



Introduction to the Special Issue: The Day-to-Day Lives of Cultures and Communities

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Abstract

In a sense, the study of everyday life epitomizes the challenges and opportunities of ethnography. The papers in this Special Issue show how the close examination of the day-to-day lives of people in idiosyncratic settings can shed light on universal questions, complicate the elegant narratives we tell ourselves about what we know, enrich our theories, and expand our sphere of empathy. Although the study of everyday life can be traced back at least as far back as the turn of the 20th century, reaching its apogee after the middle of the century, especially in the writings of Erving Goffman and Harold Garfinkel, it remains as uncommon as its object is commonplace. That is because it is easy to overlook the importance of what is happening when ‘nothing’ is happening and difficult to uncover what is significant about ‘the dust of social activity’. We argue—and the papers that follow show—that the details of the day-to-day can not only be unexpectedly interesting in their specifics but also a source of general theoretical insights about communities, organizations, and teams: their continuity, change and contradictions. What the papers have in common (with each other and with Goffman’s work) is an attention to the work that people do every day to sustain their particular self-image in the face of ongoing, mundane challenges of various sorts to the ways they like to think of and present their world and their place within it. This work to maintain the edges of meaning hides in plain sight and occupies us constantly, whether we are part of a public organization, a religious organization, a profit-seeking organization, a profit-resisting organization, an organization-less organization, or we are students of organizations marking the unremarkable.

Keywords

everyday life, organizational communities, organizational culture

In his classic, *The Interpretation of Cultures*, Clifford Geertz argues that the scientific study of humankind must seek “to encounter humanity face to face,” but warns, “the road lies, like any genuine Quest, through a terrifying complexity” (Geertz, 1973, 53–54). As any researcher who

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seeks this encounter knows, it is a road whose destination constantly recedes and often obscures as it passes through the intricate byways of day-to-day life. To embark on this journey is to avoid the convenient shortcuts of oversimplification and premature sensemaking we often take as we hurry past the routine and the mundane to get somewhere we deem significant in the worlds of the people we study. It has the advantage (or disadvantage, depending on your point of view) of complicating the elegant narratives we tell ourselves about what we know. It gives us a chance to see much that is hidden in plain sight and challenges our ability to make sense of the bewildering detail we encounter along the way.

When David Courpasson, then Editor in Chief, invited us to help organize an *Organization Studies* workshop on day-to-day organizational life, we had not imagined how many researchers out there might be fellow travelers on this quest. Although the study of everyday life can be traced at least as far back as the turn of the 20th century, reaching its apogee after the middle of the century, especially in the writings of Erving Goffman and Harold Garfinkel (Schaffer, 2000), until that workshop we had nevertheless felt that within the organizational field it remained as uncommon as the object of its study is commonplace. Encouraged by the many interesting papers and thought-provoking sessions at the workshop, we embarked upon the task of putting together this Special Issue. In our Call for Papers, we invited submissions that “further our understanding of the richness and complexity of people’s experiences, struggles, beliefs, and interpretations.” Dozens of researchers answered our call. And, to our grateful relief, an even larger number of reviewers were willing to appraise the pieces, helping us to find our way in our own day-to-day task of working with all of the submissions and ultimately choosing the papers that we are proud to present here.

We have learned a lot from *all* of the papers that were submitted. We feel that the rich variety of work being done studying the everyday life of cultures and communities deserves to be highlighted. The live views of organization, in all their different forms and voices, are critically important for enlivening the theoretical imagination, for challenging paradigmatic convictions, and for sharpening conceptualizations (Van Maanen, 1988). We also learned a lot from working as a Special Issue editorial team. In discussing the papers between us, championing their merits, expressing concern over claims we felt were perhaps not fully coming from the data, we relived with our authors Geertz’s *terrifying complexity* of writing about the quotidian. And, as a team, we found ourselves reflecting back over our own work and sharing with each other what we seem to hold as central tenets of what constitutes good research on day-to-day life. As we did so, we began to feel that of no less importance than their intellectual contributions, the live views hold the potential for expanding the sphere of empathy, helping ensure that those who see themselves as experts of organizations can deeply understand and help others to understand what it means to belong to and work in different settings, different roles, different hierarchical positions, different industrial sectors, different places in the world. To paraphrase a well-known cliché about culture, the live views of organization carry contributions to both minds and hearts.

The papers that appear in this Special Issue offer a glimpse of quite distinct organizational worlds that appear almost incomparable in terms of goals, structure, history, and so forth. Yet in each of them readers can find people struggling, day to day, with challenges and hardships that would no doubt feel familiar to them struggles that are as universal in essence as they are idiosyncratic in form and that concern, for example, valued ideals and beliefs, relationships and friendships, loneliness and fears. Ironically, perhaps, it is only through rich contextualization—through thick descriptions of the particularities that shape specific expressions of specific struggles in specific organizations—that a sense of the universal emerges in the form of in-depth understanding and sense of relatedness.

Each of the papers in this Special Issue tells a specific story that contributes to theory by delving into humdrum, everyday organizational lives to develop key insights that further knowledge and extend bodies of literature in the field. Each is thus a testament of the fact that, as Ybema, Yanow,

Wels, and Kamsteeg put it, “much of the intriguing ‘mystery’ of organizational life is hidden in the ordinary exchanges of ordinary people on an ordinary sort of day” (2009, p. 1). As we will detail in the next section, the theoretical contributions of the papers are diverse. Each concerns a distinct body of organizational thought: Kameo’s paper contributes to literature on organizational change; the paper by Pouthier contributes to literature on cross-boundary teams; the paper by Farias offers a contribution to the burgeoning literature on alternative organizations; Georgi and Palmisamo’s paper contributes to literature on institutional contradictions and identity work; and Garrett, Spreitzer, and Bacevice’s paper contributes to literature on organizational communities. Each paper descends into the details of day-to-day life as a means of producing general theoretical insights that further knowledge on distinct issues that are of interest in the field.

Moreover, alongside their individual contributions to specific theoretical literatures, we argue that the papers have an emergent joint contribution as well. What these papers have in common became clear to us only toward the end of the long process of composing the Issue, through our own inductively-oriented attempt to organize the introductory discussion that you are now reading. More specifically, when we started working on this introductory piece we tried to apply the inductive sensibility to the diverse set of papers that we are about to present by asking ourselves if such varied accounts of the everyday lives that unfold in such different contexts have anything in common. In his recent book, *Why Nothing Works: The Anthropology of Every Day Life*, Marvin Harris (2011, pp. 8–9) writes that “One important point that anthropologists have always made is that aspects of social life which do not seem to be related to each other, actually are related.” Finding that aspects of social life that don’t seem to be related to each other in the slightest are in fact intricately tied, he surfaces linkages between such seemingly unrelated events as the rise in divorce rates and shoddy consumer products, inflation and the increase in self-identified homosexuals. Is there, we wondered, a common thread that runs through the different portrayals that compose this Special Issue? And if so, what does this common thread reveal about the significance and importance of the study of everyday life for the field?

The Edges of Meaning

There is, indeed, a common thread that runs through the papers that compose this Special Issue: all show us what happens when people face ongoing, mundane challenges of various sorts to the ways they like to think of and present their world and their place within it. More specifically, the papers depict the struggles that unfold in face of ongoing inconsistencies, contradictions, or changes that are wittingly or unwittingly induced in day-to-day life that rub against the edges of collectively entrenched ways of thinking about the organization and about the organizational self. These day-to-day struggles thus unfolding at the edges of meaning bring Goffman to mind. In his 1971 book, *Relations in Public*, he referred to the “claims” that we make to ourselves and to others about who we are, what we believe, and how we are connected and differentiated from others, and stated, “At the center of social organization is the concept of claims, and around this center properly, the student must consider the vicissitudes of maintaining them.” These vicissitudes, the papers of this Special Issue illustrate, are indeed great, and their consequences theoretically surprising.

In the first paper in the Special Issue, “**A culture of uncertainty: Interaction and organizational memory in software engineering teams under a productivity scheme,**” Nahoko Kameo shows how members’ images of their organization and of their managers are *actively* entrenched in a collective memory that resists change. More specifically, the paper examines how software engineers responded to the introduction of Scrum, a new way of working when designing computer software. It is interesting to understand why the engineers resisted fully adopting Scrum given that, on its surface, the new way of working promised to offer them more autonomy and empowerment. The resistance does not come, primarily, from their dislike of Scrum or from suspicion of the

motives of management for introducing it or from general resistance to change. Rather it comes from their distrust that management will stick with Scrum, distrust that stems from a continually conjured up organizational memory of past changes that were abandoned. The engineers do not want to commit to Scrum if they feel that it might be abandoned.

In other words, the paper depicts an organizational context in which official presentations of change are actively imbued with uncertainty and doubt. The engineers parse every statement and action by management and by other teams in the company trying to read what are the implications for the future of Scrum. And their interpretations are colored by their pessimism, based on the organization's track record of previous changes, that abandonment is likely. In a sense, then, official presentations by, and informal interactions with, team leaders were constantly and actively "edged" by members who read the past into the present; who read against the grain of official presentations. Since the nature of Scrum is that it requires trust and shared mental models among the engineers, because they were hypersensitive to signs that other teams were not doing full Scrum, they did not do full Scrum. Rendering the organization intelligible through an overarching and repeatedly reaffirmed narrative of superficially-embraced-and-then-painfully-aborted changes, the engineers' response was to pull back enough from commitment to Scrum that its form was maintained but its substance was subverted. Extending theory on organizational change, Kameo thus identifies organizational memory as a cultural resource that members use to enact commitment and resistance.

If the software engineers that Kameo studied used organizational memory as a cultural resource with which they struggled to make sense of and resist a formally espoused change, then the people whom Vanessa Pouthier studied used different cultural resources—namely, humor and complaints—to sustain their identity as a united team despite the structural contradictions and tensions that beset it. In her paper, **"Gripping and joking as identification rituals and tools for engagement in cross-boundary team meetings,"** Pouthier takes us to a cross-boundary team in a palliative care/oncology unit in a large hospital. The paper is about how members in this unit sustain their sense of being a "team" despite differences in occupational perspective (acute care versus palliative care) and differences in power and status between departments and functions, and the fact that people had higher affinity with their occupational communities than with the team. The setting is full of tension—death and dying are all around, people are overworked—and cross-functional teamwork is required both by law and for positive patient outcomes. The team has no leader, no formal goals or agenda for its meetings, and shifting composition of members.

Relationships are built through everyday griping about their shared circumstances and joking about their occupational and status differences. By griping together good-naturedly about the difficult working conditions they share, challenging patients and families, and other healthcare providers not in the room at the time, they come together in commiseration and shared moral identity. By joking about the differences among them in perspective towards patients and their relative power and status, they raise these issues in a way that allows them to recognize them while temporarily suspending them, surfacing them with enough ambiguity to prevent disharmony. Deriving a theoretical model of managing the tensions inherent to cross-boundary teams through the use of joking and complaining to strengthen affinity, Pouthier richly demonstrates the way both served to strengthen, affirm, and sustain the image of a united professional team despite its ongoing difficulties and the lack of unity of occupational perspective.

In the third and fourth papers the edges of meaning are imbued with deep ideological and religious significance. In **"Money is the root of all evil—or is it? Recreating culture through everyday neutralizing practices,"** Carine Farias explores everyday life in Longo Mai, an intentional community that seeks to oppose the capitalist order. With a history that dates back to the late 1960s, Longo Mai is an organization that sees itself as fulfilling an alternative model of collective life. Yet it turns out that in order to survive and to promote its ideology, Longo Mai is dependent

upon one of the most powerful symbols of the capitalist order that it so passionately resists: money. In order to sustain its activities, it needs to engage in both fundraising and commerce. Drawing from classical writers in anthropology and sociology, Farias thus argues that money constitutes a “dirty object” in this cultural universe, and notes the risk it entails for transgressing and polluting the group’s shared classification of values and meanings. Moreover, Farias further illustrates that the challenge posed by this “dirty object” is not merely a marginal occurrence that can easily be denied or brushed aside, but is an ongoing difficulty.

Longo Mai’s “dirty object,” then, repeatedly reveals the fragile edges of the community’s own valued, oppositional self-image. A community that fashions itself as an alternative to the capitalist order has to repeatedly face its own entanglement in that order, and, moreover, to deal with the consequent threat of transgressing the boundaries that define what “alternative” could and does actually mean. Interestingly, however, Farias further argues that this “dirty object” is not merely an ideological and cultural threat but also a creative force. The processes through which members confront and seek to neutralize money’s uses—namely, “distancing” and “re-appropriating”—lubricate the dynamic flow of everyday life and smooth out the tensions in ways that, surprisingly perhaps, are culturally productive. Inciting the development of dynamic, responsive, and heterogeneous forms of alternative cultural practices and scripts, the neutralizing processes facilitate the development of what Farias calls “a relational and politicized culture of exchange.” Identifying the cultural potential stemming from a group’s inability to completely rid itself of that which it renders a “dirty object,” Farias thus furthers our theoretical understanding of the cultural implications of the complex entanglement of alternative organizations in the system they resist and contributes theoretical insights concerning the creative (albeit somewhat ironic) role of persistent symbolic threats in the shaping of organizational cultures.

In **“Sober intoxication: Institutional contradictions and identity work in the everyday life of four religious communities in Italy”**, Simona Giorgi and Stefania Palmisano take us to a site where people’s most deeply felt truths concerning the order of things are invoked and formulated through the realm of the sacred: religious communities. Even here, we learn, notions of the absolute can routinely run the course of having to face their own edges. Giorgi and Palmisano’s context of study are four mystical religious communities whose members also belong to the Catholic Church. Located in Italy, these mystical communities are characterized by a worldview and a set of ceremonial and religious practices that, as far as mainstream Catholicism is concerned, are highly suspect. Since members of these communities define themselves both as mystics and as Roman Catholics, their religious experience is replete with a sense of identity-tension. The conflicting religious prescriptions continually surface the edges of each religious worldview, necessitating an ongoing “identity work” to reconcile the experience of these institutional contradictions.

Giorgi and Palmisano are right when they define their context of study “an extreme setting.” Their case study indicates that even in organizational worlds whose notions of truth are literally and most comprehensively sanctified, the experience of contradictions and inconsistencies can become routine. Moreover, their analysis further traces the inner echoes of these contradictions at the level of self. It reveals the ways through which members turn their own sense of self into a site of stabilization where temporary truces are reached and contradictions are partly reconciled. Rather than seeking institutional change as a means of eliminating the tensions and forging coherence between the conflicting religious scripts, members resort to identity work that allows for the reflective maintenance of the institutions they belong to, despite all the tensions. Giorgi and Palmisano call the primary mechanisms of this identity work “distancing” and “embedding,” and their analysis illustrates the ways that these mechanisms enable the flow of everyday life, smoothing out those rough edges of religious meaning that the conflicting cultural scripts continually bring to light. Using their findings and analytical insights to build a dynamic model of managing institutional contradictions, Giorgi and Palmisano extend theory by pointing out how these institutional

contradictions are not just disruptive catalysts of change, but also serve as essential components to organizational maintenance.

In the fifth paper, **“Co-constructing a sense of community at work: The emergence of community in co-working spaces,”** Lyndon Garrett, Gretchen Spreitzer, and Peter Bacevice discuss the efforts of members of a co-working space to enact a collective sense of community. In their analysis, the authors trace the source of these efforts to the painful experience of loneliness that working at home entails for certain people. As members’ narratives indicated, after a job change or relocation had led them to start working from home, they encountered a frustrating sense of social isolation. Whatever images they once held about the realities of working from home, and about their own work-related personal needs, the actual work-from-home experience has apparently forced them to realize the existence of “a social void,” and to acknowledge their own overwhelming desire for collective identity, friendships, and a sense of influence and social importance. Facing and coping with realizations that defy any individualistic images of their own working selves, members sought a sense of community.

Their attempt to forge this community, however, required constant effort. We tend to think of sense of community as something that grows organically, but this paper describes the creation of community in the most artificial way imaginable. These people have nothing in common except a desire to be part of a community. The community has no reason for being except the desire of its members to exist. It is analogous to a child with no friends at school identifying another child he doesn’t know but who looks like he has no friends either and going up to him and saying, “Do you want to be my friend?” It is like a romantic relationship between two people who have nothing in common except a common desire to have someone in their life to love. The paper describes how this community of community-seekers sustains itself through everyday affirmation, in words and behaviors, of their shared desire for community. It shows the work they have to do to convince themselves that this community is as real as, more real than, communities that form in traditional workplaces, and to protect their belief in the strength of the community from signs that not everyone is fully committed to it. They are growing a lawn in the desert—sustaining their image of a community requires constant watering and attention. Garrett, Spreitzer, and Bacevice use their unique case study to develop a theoretical model of how the sense of community is co-constructed in non-traditional work spaces where unity is negotiated differentially from leader-driven, shared values toward organizational performance.

The papers thus all concern attempts to sustain a particular self-image: the self-image of a fadish, non-committing organization (Kameo) or of a united team (Pouthier); an alternative and resistant self-image (Farias); the self-image of normative Catholics (Georgi & Palmisano); and the self-image of an ideal community (Garrett, Spreitzer, & Bacevice). All these images require forms of repair work in face of contradictions, inconsistencies, and tensions that mark out their threatening edges. Seen together, the papers provide a collage of different forms of the everyday protection against what Goffman long ago described as the vicissitudes of everyday life.

That the ghost of Erving Goffman touches each of the papers in this Special Issue is perhaps no surprise. Goffman, “the quintessential sociologist of everyday life,” according to the editors of his collected works (Lemert & Branaman, 1977), was not only responsible for elevating a subject treated by sociologists before him as “the dust of social activity, empty and trivial” (Goffman, 1971, p. 90) to something worthy of serious consideration and study, but masterfully dissected the meaning and importance of everyday life with a remarkable and cutting discernment. Resonating with his insights, the papers in this Special Issue teach us two things about the maintenance work that is required to preserve the ways that we like to think of our world against real and potential threats: it tends to hide in plain sight and it occupies us constantly. The edges of meaning are not peripheral, nor do they require exceptional dramas (e.g., Ailon, 2011) to bring them to pass. Rather, they seem to be a central aspect of daily organizational life.

Furthermore, the papers illustrate the dynamic outcomes of edge dynamics. In some cases, namely those described in Farias's paper about an alternative organization and in Georgi and Palmisano's paper about a religious community, these dynamics lead members to try and reconcile the contradictory themes, inciting reflexivity, negotiation, and boundary work (i.e., "distancing"). In the case of Garrett, Spreitzer, and Bacevice's study of a co-working space, these dynamics seem to inspire quite extensive everyday affirmations. In Pouthier's paper about the cross-functional hospital team they incite humor and griping. And in the case of Kameo's paper about the software developers they seem to breed, and to be bred by, a culture of suspicion. In sum, reflexivity, negotiation, boundary work, affirmations, humor, griping, and suspicion provide in different ways what Fine and Hallett call "the tensile strength of organizations in the face of forces of alienation or uncertainty that might otherwise disrupt allegiance" (2014, p. 1778). They are each different ways of confronting those aspects of day-to-day life that transcend (or that threaten to transcend) the ideologically, normatively, emotionally, and even religiously entrenched ways through which members collectively make sense of their world and of their place within it.

David Courpasson, whom we invited to contribute the closing essay to this Special Issue, would no doubt add that these dynamics unfolding at the edges of meaning are also deeply political. His piece adds a complex, theoretically nuanced perspective that underscores the extent to which the open-ended, creative, and unexpected everyday dynamics at work constitute a complex politics of submission and resistance. His argument is that submission and resistance are undecisively intermingled in everyday life for the simple reason that what Van Maanen (2011, p. xviii) calls "the intricate ways individuals and groups understand, accommodate, and resist a presumably shared order" is the stuff life is made of, or, more properly, the stuff with which we make our lives.

As a whole, the Special Issue thus illustrates how the study of the everyday can help uncover the commonplace but often submerged dramas that unfold in the interstices of collectively espoused images of or beliefs about life. It may appear odd to think of the mundane, of the seemingly banal, as an ongoing and highly political drama of treading the edges of meaning, of coping—wittingly or not—with all that defies, challenges or otherwise threatens the socially, emotionally, and morally invested systems of meaning through which we understand and experience organizational life. But on second thought, it actually makes sense. After all, the mundane is where life actually happens. And life, John Lennon sang to us many years ago, has this tendency to resist that which we think we know: "Life is what happens to you while you're busy making other plans."¹

In a sense, then, the Special Issue portrays the day-to-day processes that render this lyric so true. It illustrates the lubrication that keeps people's wheels moving: we see how people get through their day despite the contradictions they (and we all) face. Indeed, the papers bear evidence not merely of the fact that contradictions and inconsistencies exist, but also of how they can be dynamically "smoothed out" at the level of the individual (Georgi and Palmisano's paper about the religious communities), the team (Pouthier's paper about the cross-functional hospital team), and the organization (Farias's paper about the alternative organization and Garrett, Spreitzer, and Bacevice's paper about the co-working space). Additionally, the Special Issue shows that contradictions and inconsistencies can be dynamically heightened and emphasized (Kameo's paper about software engineers; and also Courpasson's closing essay).

In order to appreciate how surprising these aggregate findings are, let us broadly compare them to the type of analytical expectations that often guide the theoretical imagination. First, the finding that contradictions and inconsistencies are hardly marginal in day-to-day illustrates how much is empirically lost through positivist analytical strategies that project upon the empirical world their own criteria of logic instead of turning logic—emic logic—into an empirical question. Second, the finding that contradictions and inconsistencies can be interactionally monitored and re-fashioned problematizes Marxist-based expectations regarding their inherently radical force. Third, it indicates what is missing in postmodernist type of accounts that tend to assume the proliferation of

contradictions and inconsistencies, but overlook the fact that they are often actively smoothed out—turned into a bridge between institutional logics (Georgi & Palmisano), into a functional force (Pouthier), into a culturally creative force (Farias and Garrett et al.), or into a means of forging coherence with the past (even at the price of heightening tensions in the present) (Kameo). It is precisely this ability of studies of everyday life to unsettle that which we think we know that renders them so critically important for the field.

The Importance of the Study of Everyday Organizational Life

In a recent essay, Karl Weick argued that organizational research is not, nor should it aspire to be, a “settled science.” “Organizational research,” he writes, “prepares people for what they don’t see and don’t know. In other words, it builds capacity more than solves problems” (Weick, 2016, p. 342). Acts of inquiry are valuable in and of themselves when they alter meaning as well as constraints of comprehension. The study of everyday life seems to us to be especially valuable in this regard. Exploring those aspects of life that are broadly viewed as usual, unremarkable, and even banal by the people living it, researchers of everyday life focus precisely on those dimensions of organizational life that are easily overlooked and, when noticed, are easily dismissed as uninteresting. They examine what is happening when it seems like nothing is happening. Whether looking at contexts that are distant from those of the researchers and their intended audience or those closer to home, the study of everyday life holds the potential of lifting the constraints of comprehension that prevent us from seeing the eventfulness of the seemingly commonplace. In the case of distant or unusual contexts, comparisons to what we ourselves find routine or even mundane can reveal both the similarities and the differences: making the others feel less strange to us by domesticating the seeming exotic and causing us to recognize what we might otherwise take for granted in our own lives. Marking what is seen as unremarkable in contexts we think we already know can reveal the function and significance of behaviors we otherwise overlook because they are so prevalent.

This holds true both for organizational members and for organizational scholars. Regarding the former, as organizational routines and procedures become entrenched and taken for granted, they are generally enacted uncritically and without awareness of any need for change nor of the resources available for change. Studies of everyday life can surface these hidden dimensions. Consider, for example, Brannen, Mughan, and Moore’s (2013) account of the “strategic ethnography” conducted in Tesco Plc, a global food retailer and Britain’s largest private sector employer at that time. In this project, an academic research team deployed insider/outsider bicultural bridges by training nine Asian subsidiary managers to become in-house ethnographers of Tesco UK. By observing day-to-day routines and processes, and by comparing and contrasting them with those of their home country, these ethnographers facilitated learning by surfacing various underlying organizational identity fissures. Moreover, as a whole, this action-based research study revealed everyday knowledge that people within their own local context didn’t know they had.

Additionally, the study of everyday life can also enrich theories of behavior, broaden the scholarly imagination, and enlarge the scope of our descriptive understanding of organizations. These virtues seem especially critical today. As a number of renowned organizational scholars have recently argued, the commitment to knowledge development in the field is currently impeded in two primary ways: institutional pressures limit our theoretical goals and values, preventing us from fully capturing dramatic changes in the world of organizations (Barley, 2016; Davis, 2015), and analytical frameworks tend to limit our empirical field of vision (Kunda, 2013).

We do not wish to add to these ruminations, but to explain why we believe that deep immersion in the everyday lives of those who belong to and are impacted by organizations is critical for overcoming both of these problems. First, let us consider the issue of theoretical goals and values. As Davis (2015, p. 179) explains, “changes in the world of organizations are not being met with

changes in how and for whom organizational research is done.” Given the impact of organizations and the dramatic reconfigurations of their structures and operations, he argues, there is a need to rethink our research goals and include a broader vision of the public’s benefit, including workers, consumers, and citizens.

“Broadening the vision,” however, is much more difficult to achieve than it appears. Among the various strategies for achieving this broader vision—new theoretical resources, new statistical strategies, etc.—immersion in the day-to-day lives of the different constituents of organizations seems to us to be both the most promising and the bravest. Many analytical strategies tend to distance scholars from the “real,” mundane lives of those who belong to or are routinely impacted by organizations. Analytically sophisticated as they may be, they often entail the price of moral, emotional, and social simplifications. Broadening our vision through studies of day-to-day lives no doubt entails an unsettling, *terrifying complexity* in all these terms. It clarifies the social and moral challenges and contingencies of organizational research, and it carries the potential to breathe actual life into abstract scientific values.

Second, studies of day-to-day life hold the potential to yield the unexpected, inductive insight that—according to Eisenhardt, Graebner, and Sonenshein (2016)—is critical for adding “rigor” and avoiding “rigor mortis” in the field. To a great extent, there seems to us to be a proclivity in organization studies to search for the known or pursue a “science of the obvious,” often through deductive hypothesis testing that relies on sophisticated quantitative methodologies for isolating, controlling, and manipulating variables. But, as Harris (2011, pp. 8–9) reminds us, given the surprising cultural interrelations between aspects of social life, “we cannot hope to understand why any aspect of a people’s way of life has changed if we view it in isolation.” Returning to John Lennon, the busy plans of the deductive theory tester thus tend to be quite removed from the life that is actually happening, often right in front of our eyes.

In contrast, researching life as it actually happens holds the potential to stretch our understanding beyond what we (and perhaps also the people we study) take for granted. Indeed, as Kunda (2013) notes, actual interactions with the people who are studied tend to surface the limits of the interpretive tools which are grounded in theory, inviting a reliance on a broader set of symbolic tools that have been developed over the researcher’s lifetime and that are critical for the generation of new insight. The attempt to deeply understand the lives of the people who are studied enables researchers to face, grapple with, and enrich the bounds of the theoretical imagination. It is a way of purposely searching for the edges of our own analytical images; of actively surfacing the blind and blinding spots of theory.

In the context of organizational studies, where a substantial portion of the knowledge produced has historically taken the shape of administrative plans and managerial prescriptions, the idea that life is what happens to you when you are busy making other plans seems an especially poignant reminder that we should not lose sight of daily life as it actually unfolds. Our hope is that this Special Issue, which brings to you accounts of the lives of people who take part in all sorts of organizations—a public organization (by Pouthier), a religious organization (by Georgi & Palisano), a profit-seeking (by Kameo) and a profit-resisting (by Farias) organization, and even an organization-less organization (by Garrett et al.)—evokes the intricate scope of our disciplinary mandate and the value of studies of everyday life in enriching our thinking and deepening our understanding of organizations. The journey along Geertz’s road, like any genuine Quest, is one where we learn more by paying close attention along the way than by arriving at what we or those we study suppose to be Oz.

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Note

1. Lennon used that quote in his song, *Beautiful Boy*, but he didn't come up with it. According to the *Yale Book of Quotations* editors Fred R. Shapiro and Joseph Epstein (2006), it originated with the writer and cartoonist Allen Saunders. And a variation of it appeared in *Reader's Digest* in 1957.

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